Introduction to International Politics 2601

Anarchy and Classical Realism

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Anarchy

Anarchy -

- the absence of a central authority (in the international system)

Realism assumes the **international system** is naturally **anarchic**.

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... *Why is this important?*

Anarchy -

- influences actors' behaviors
- ... *but in what ways?*

Recall: Theories of IR -

- explain
- predict

We rely on theories - or **sets of assumptions about the international system and the actors in it** - to understand events in international politics and to speak to the consequences of these events.

Recall: Our **glasses analogy** -

- theories help us "see" international politics in a particular ways
- we look to specific details of actors and their environments to understand their motivations
- the theories of IR "see" international politics differently based on the assumptions they make... including the role of **anarchy**.

Anarchy -

- influences actors' behaviors
- ... *but in what ways?*

Anarchy -

- influences actors' behaviors
- ... *but in what ways?* **through effects of power dynamics (Realism), incentives for cooperation (Liberalism), ideas/identity (Constructivism)**

Realist "Glasses"

- we look to the **sources and implications of power** dynamics to understand states' interests

Realism (Principles)

Anarchy in Realism -

- Anarchy implies a constant *state of conflict*.

Anarchy in Realism -

- no constraints on states' behavior (passive permissions)
- important to states direct interests

Hobbes (8)

"during the time men live without a common power to keep them all in awe, they are in that condition which is called war, and such a war as is of every man against every man."

War in Hobbes' -

- the *potential* for conflict to arise
- adapted to our understanding of states' interests

Notes -

- A *state of conflict* creates the potential for war.
- For now, we might think of "peace" as the absence of war.

Anarchy - Key Takeaway (Realism)

- it creates the conditions for countries to engage in war

The "Black Box"

Unit of Study (Realism)

- "Actors" in the international system = countries (hereafter, *states*)
- The international system is anarchic, and *states are the primary actors*.
- Realism asks: *What are the states doing?*

The "Black Box" -

- there is a "sameness" among states)
- all states are expected to make the same decisions under the same pressures
- The "sameness" among states stems from a focus on *system level* (i.e., international) factors

[INSERT COUNTRY
NAME HERE]

The "Black Box")

- **States are the primary actors** in the international system
- states motivations are **material** but relate to **power**

Power

Power -

- power dynamics are important
- states are concerned with *relative power*
- power gains are zero-sum

Notes -

- It is in the state's advantage to have greater capabilities than other states.
- mostly considers **hard power**

Hard power -

- relying on the sources of military strength
- coercive (in contrast to *soft power* being "attractive")
- examples - alliance behavior, military military action
- States focus on their military strength and economic resources relative to other states in the international system.

Hard power -

- States focus on their military strength and economic resources relative to other states in the international system.

Summary: Principles of Realism

- ✓Anarchy→conflict
- ✓Hard power (ability to conduct war)
- ✓States are the primary actors
- ✓Relative power (*greater* ability than other states)

Classical Realism

Classical Realism -

- **Realpolitik** over ideological/moral influences
- Note examples: Sun Tzu (*The Art of War*), Thucydides

Realpolitik

- the influence of practical considerations in international politics (conflict)

Thucydides 89

"the strong do what they have the power to do and the weak accept what they have to accept"

Classical Realism -

- **Realpolitik** over ideological/moral influences
- draws parallels between **human nature** (fear, aggression as motivators) and states' conquest in the international system
- assumes that *states seek power* (as an end in itself)

Hobbes 7

"So that in the nature of man we find three principal causes of quarrel. First, *competition* [gain]; secondly, *diffidence* [saftey]; thirdly, *glory* [reputation]."

Next lecture: Realism Pt. II - Structural Realism (Neorealism)